

In any case, you read with exasperation or amusement the multiple errors in a story—and then turn the page to national or international affairs, and read with renewed interest as if the rest of the newspaper was somehow more accurate about far-off Palestine than it was about the story you just read. You turn the page, and forget what you know.

That is the most damning indictment of speculative stories, opinion pieces, and general nonsense that passes for journalism you will ever read.

“If somebody consistently exaggerates or lies to you,” Crichton continues, you soon stop believing anything they say. Referencing the legal doctrine “*falsus in uno, falsus in omnibus*”—translation: “Untruthful in one part, untruthful in all”—he observes that “we do not apply the same standard to “movies, television, internet, books, newspapers, and magazines.”

We obviously should.



Next, we apply Crichton’s standard to the media, and see how the daily headlines age. Spoiler alert: *Not well*.

¹⁰¹ Michael Crichton, “Why Speculate?” International Leadership Forum, La Jolla, California (April 26, 2002).